



Black-backed jackal

Canis mesomelas

- ↔ 18–35 in (45–90 cm)
- 📍 E. and Southern Africa
- ⊗ Common

An adaptable and resourceful species, the black-backed jackal is a common sight in eastern and southern Africa, from city suburbs to remote deserts. Males and females mate for life and live as a pair, hunting their own prey and scavenging from the kills of others. They eat a huge variety of animals, as well as fruit and berries. Each pair has its own territory, centered on a den, such as an old aardvark hole, where they rear their family.

Red wolf

Canis rufus

- ↔ 3–4 ft (1–1.2 m)
- 📍 Reintroduced to E. US
- ⊗ Critically endangered

Smaller than the gray wolf, and with a red tinge to its gray-brown fur, the red wolf once lived throughout the eastern states of the US but was reduced to near-extinction by hunting and interbreeding with coyotes. Reintroduced to the wild in North Carolina from 1987, the species built up a small wild population, but its future is still in serious doubt. It lives in family-based packs and hunts mammals such as rabbits and raccoons.

Bat-eared fox

Otocyon megalotis

- ↔ 18–26 in (46–66 cm)
- 📍 E. and Southern Africa
- ⊗ Common

This long-legged, small-headed African fox is a specialized insect-eater. It uses its huge ears to pinpoint the location of its prey on the savanna, targeting the harvester termites that swarm over the grasslands. It also eats other insects such as dung beetles and grasshoppers. Compared with other foxes, it has smaller teeth and more of them (with up to eight extra molars), an adaptation to its small prey.

Sun bear

Helarctos malayanus

- ↔ 4–5 ft (1–1.5 m)
- 📍 SE. Asia
- ⊗ Vulnerable

Mainly black or rusty-brown with a U-shaped pale patch on its chest, the sun bear is the smallest of the bears and the only one adapted for life in tropical rainforests. A good climber, it sleeps in trees and feeds mainly on fruit and insects. It breaks into termite mounds for prey and rips hollow trees apart to get at the nests of bees so it can devour their honey and larvae.

Asiatic black bear

Ursus thibetanus

- ↔ 4–6 ft (1.2–1.8 m)
- 📍 E., S., and SE. Asia
- ⊗ Vulnerable

Also known as the moon bear because of the white crescent on its black chest, this species is similar to the American black bear. It spends much of its time in trees, foraging for nuts and fruit, but also eats bamboo shoots, grasses, and insects. Deforestation has destroyed much of its forest habitat, and as a result, it sometimes raids farm crops, coming into direct and sometimes fatal conflict with humans.

Common seal

Phoca vitulina

- ↔ 5–6 ft (1.5–1.8 m)
- 📍 North Atlantic, North Pacific
- ⊗ Common

Also known as the harbor seal, this is the most widespread of the seals, ranging along the coasts of both the northern Pacific and Atlantic oceans, as well as some Arctic seas. The common seal has a small, rounded, catlike head with large eyes and distinctive V-shaped nostrils and is very variable in color. It preys mainly on fish, which it catches on short dives lasting just three to four minutes each.



pale gray-brown fur with small rings and blotches

Crabeater seal

Lobodon carcinophaga

- ↔ 7–9 ft (2.1–2.7 m)
- 📍 Antarctic and subantarctic waters
- ⊗ Common

Despite its name, this Antarctic true seal is specialized for catching the shrimplike krill that form vast swarms in the Southern Ocean. Its elaborately lobed teeth interlock to form a sieve when its jaws are closed, allowing it to strain the krill from the water rather than seizing them individually. It rests and breeds on drifting pack ice and is a regular target for killer whales and leopard seals.

Weddell seal

Leptonychotes weddellii

- ↔ 8–10 ft (2.5–3 m)
- 📍 Antarctic and subantarctic waters
- ⊗ Common

The deep-diving Weddell seal hunts fish and other marine animals beneath the sea ice that fringes the Antarctic coast. It can stay underwater for over an hour, but must maintain a breathing hole in the ice above. To do this, the seal enlarges cracks in the ice with its teeth—as a result, many Weddell seals suffer from worn teeth and dental abscesses, which can prove fatal.

Baikal seal

Pusa sibirica

- ↔ 4–5 ft (1.2–1.5 m)
- 📍 E. Asia (Lake Baikal)
- ⊗ Locally common

Although closely related to the ringed seal of the Arctic Ocean, this small, sleek seal lives only in Lake Baikal in Siberia, the deepest freshwater lake in the world. Like all true seals, it swims effortlessly, propelling itself with its rear-facing hindlimbs. The males stay in the water all winter, hunting fish beneath the ice, but in late winter, the females haul out onto the ice to bear their white-coated pups.

